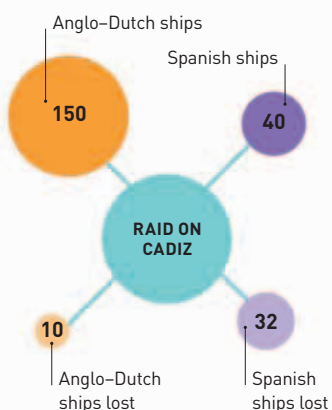




Despite the perils of the venture, all four Dutch ships that set out for the East Indies in 1595 made it back safely to Amsterdam with their cargo in 1599.

THE FINAL CONVULSIONS OF THE FRENCH WARS OF RELIGION

(1562–98) were played out after 1595. **Henry IV** (see 1588–89), by his conversion to Catholicism in 1593, succeeded in winning broad acceptance as king. Yet his conversion aroused the suspicions of the **Huguenots**—fearful he now intended to turn against them—and did nothing to appease the ambitions of the leaders of the **Catholic League**, whose goal was not merely the extermination of Protestantism in France but the seizure of the throne. Henry's response, in January 1595, was to **declare war on Spain**. His aim was both to eradicate the Catholic League, supported by Spain, while demonstrating to the Huguenots that, Catholic or not, he was no puppet of the Spanish monarchy. An early French victory in June



Raid on Cadiz

The Spanish lost 80 percent of the fleet anchored at Cadiz. They set many of their ships on fire to deny the Anglo-Dutch raiders their prize.



1595 against a combined Spanish-Catholic League force in Burgundy was followed the following spring by a renewed Spanish offensive that saw the capture of Calais and Amiens. The inevitable sieges by Henry followed, and the capitulation of Amiens in September 1597 marked his final triumph.

Until the beginning of the Dutch Revolt in 1566, the Netherlands largely dominated the **lucrative maritime trade** between Spain and Portugal and northern Europe—it was Dutch ships that carried spices and other New World goods from Iberia to the north. Thereafter, forbidden to trade with Iberian ports and conscious of the failings of Spain's maritime reach highlighted by the Armada, the **Dutch determined to break into the spice trade**. In 1595, four Dutch ships under Cornelius van Houten sailed for

Anglo-Dutch fleet attacks Cadiz
Nominally a joint Anglo-Dutch operation, in reality, of the 150 ships in the fleet that attacked Cadiz in 1596, 130 were English.

the East Indies. The crews endured scurvy and repeated clashes with local rulers and the Portuguese, and van Houten was killed in Sumatra. When, in 1599, the beleaguered fleet returned to Amsterdam, it brought with it an apparently meager quantity of spices, yet this was enough to secure a huge profit. The stage for Dutch domination of the East India trade was set (see 1602–03).

One of **England's few successes** in its participation in the Dutch Revolt was a **raid on Cadiz** in southern Spain in July 1596. Much like Drake's raid in 1587, it caused enormous devastation, with most of the city destroyed, and contributed to the bankruptcy of the Spanish crown in 1597.



This ceiling fresco at Chehel Sotoun Palace in Isfahan, Iran, shows Shah Abbas I, seated on the right, playing host to Vali Muhammad Khan of Bukara.

ALTHOUGH THE BANNING OF

CHRISTIANITY IN JAPAN had been enforced only partially since 1587, in December 1596, certain that Spain and Portugal were using Christian penetration as a prelude to conquest, Toyotomi ordered the **deaths of 26 Christians**—six Franciscan missionaries and 20 Japanese. On February 5, 1597, in Nagasaki, they were strapped to crosses and speared to death. The significance of their deaths was less that Christianity would not be tolerated in Japan, and more that any challenge to the central authority would not be allowed.

The uneasy compromise brokered by Henry IV in France after 1597 was symbolized by the **Edict of Nantes** of April 1598. Under it, Protestants in France were granted the right to organize a quasi-independent state within France. Not only could they practice their religion freely—other than in Paris—but the Crown guaranteed their security, paying them to garrison their towns. Nothing if not pragmatic—and effective enough in the short term in **ending the French Wars of Religion**—inevitably it satisfied no one. The Huguenots still felt themselves unequally treated compared to the Catholics, while the latter were horrified that the Huguenots should be tolerated at all, let alone protected.

The accession in 1587 of the 16-year-old **Abbas I** as the **shah of Safavid Persia** rejuvenated its fortunes. Under his father Shah Mohammed, Persia had been in a state of near civil war created by



WILLIAM SHAKESPEARE
(1564–1616)

William Shakespeare exerted more influence on English literature and European drama than any other writer. The son of a Stratford-upon-Avon wool dealer, he was an actor turned author, and wrote at least 37 plays and 154 sonnets. He is believed to have written the tragedy *Hamlet* around 1599–1602. He also excelled at comedy.

rival factions within the Qizilbash army and had lost substantial territories to the Ottomans and Uzbeks. Abbas set about a **major reform of his rebellious army**, drafting in new troops, principally from the Caucasus, who were directly loyal to him. He rearmed them with muskets supplied by an English diplomat, Sir Anthony Shirley, who was negotiating an Anglo-Persian anti-Ottoman treaty. Between April and August 1598, Abbas launched a **major campaign against the Uzbeks**, driving them from the northwest of Persia.

